Flybird's irrigation controller installed at Gavit's place (Credit: Satish K.S.)

sistent water availability, Netafim, an Israel-based agri-automation solution provider, took charge of the project. The project based on a 2150-km-long pipeline network has smart control systems inside a centrally controlled unit in the village, which the farm owners can operate as necessary. It will automate the water supply and also provide intel on water availability and water quality being drawn.

This project is poised to be a major benefactor for the native agri community. At a cost of ₹ 1300 per year, which is to be deposited by individual farmers, each of them are expected to receive a substantial amount of productivity improvement. Additionally, the region will see a lot of water being saved, which is otherwise wasted through sub-optimal application.

More such stories of successful implementations and operations can be found throughout the country.

## Cost points

Technology and solutions being developed need to be cost-effective, keeping in mind the affordability factor for the agri community. So the manufacturers are cautious. For example, Energy Bot's smart watering system is priced at about ₹4500. Their automated irrigation solution starts from ₹ 15,000, with variable price range based on the area of land to cover, number of sensors needed and scale of application.

For solar pumps, the cost may start from ₹ 50,000 per horse power capacity. Administrative bodies like Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) provide a 25 per cent subsidy on these pumps, while state governments provide an additional variable subsidy between 50 and 70 per cent. Putting these into the equation, farm owners will be required to pay about 10 to 25 per cent of the total cost.

## The final word

Automation in the field can have a great positive impact, both financially as well as environmentally. Satish concludes, "These technologies can save water by 25 to 30 per cent, improve overall crop yield by 10 to 15 per cent, eliminate human errors, save electricity, reduce weeds and optimise agricultural inputs. All of this adds up to an improved livelihood for the agri community."

India's exhilaration towards automating agriculture shows a promising future. More adoption of technology can greatly improve India's environmental and financial gains from its lands. EFY